1] Location & Geography

- **Village:** Molela, Rajsamand district, Rajasthan.
- **Nearest City:** Udaipur (45 km).
- **Geography:**
  - Located on the banks of the **Banas River** , the only clay source for this craft.
  - Semi-arid climate with hot summers, mild winters.
  - River clay here has special smoothness and strength.
- **Climate Influence:**
  - Clay collection possible only in dry months (Oct–March).
  - Monsoons make clay too wet; work slows down.

Demography (Pie Charts)

- **Population:** ~3,000–4,000 people.
- **Main Communities:** Kumhar (potters), Bhil, Garasiya, Rawat, Gujjar.

Pie Chart 1 – Work Profile:

- Pottery/Craft – 60%
- Agriculture – 25%
- Small trade – 10%
- Other jobs – 5%

Pie Chart 2 – Caste Factor:

- Kumhar – 55%
- Bhil – 20%
- Garasiya – 10%
- Others – 15%

2]About the Craft

- Molela is a small village in **Rajsamand district, Rajasthan**, famous for making **terracotta plaques** (flat clay panels).
- The craft is over **800 years old** and is passed down through **Kumhar families** from generation to generation.
- These plaques show **Hindu gods, folk stories, village life, and nature**.

- Traditionally, they were made for **tribal communities** who used them in **shrines called devras** instead of stone temples.
- The main raw material is **clay from the Banas River**, mixed with donkey dung and wheat husk.
- All work is done by **hand**, from shaping and carving to painting and finishing.
- The plaques are **lightweight, hollow**, and decorated with **bright colors** or **natural red geru**.
- Today, they are sold not only for worship but also for **home décor, gifts, and exports**.
- Every year in *Magh* month, old plaques are replaced with new ones.
- Local legend: A blind potter made an idol of the god *Devnarayan* and got back his eyesight — since then, the craft is seen as sacred.

Tools

- **Pindi** – cement mallet for flattening clay evenly.
- **Paatya** – flat wooden or stone slab to work on.
- **Bhaledi** – pointed tool for cutting and shaping details.
- **Channi** – sieve to remove stones and dirt from clay.
- Small tools like combs, wires, and toothpicks are used for patterns and textures.

Materials Used

Material	Local Name	Use
River clay	—	Main body of plaque
Donkey dung	*Gid*	Prevents cracks, binds clay
Wheat husk	—	Adds strength
Red oxide	*Geru*	Natural color pigment
Lacquer	—	Shine and water protection

Clay is collected only in certain seasons when riverbanks are dry.

Natural materials make the plaques sustainable and biodegradable.

Pre-Process of Clay

1. **Collection:** Clay dug from Banas River banks when dry.
2. **Cleaning:** Passed through *chalni* (metal sieve) to remove stones, twigs, and dirt.
3. **Mixing:**
   - Clay + donkey dung (*gid*) → prevents cracks.
   - Wheat husk → adds strength.
4. **Kneading:** Softened by hands and feet for 20–30 mins.
5. **Resting:** Clay covered and left overnight to improve flexibility.

PROCESS

Stage 1: Clay Collection

- Clay is collected from the banks of the **Banas River** near Molela.
- Only certain spots give the fine, smooth clay needed for plaques.

- Collected during the dry season when riverbanks are exposed.

Stage 2: Cleaning the Clay

- Clay is passed through a **metal sieve (Channi)** to remove stones, twigs, and lumps.
- Clean clay is essential to avoid cracks while drying.

Stage 3: Mixing Materials

- The clay is mixed with **donkey dung (Gid)** and **wheat husk**.
- Dung prevents cracking during drying; husk gives extra strength.
- Water is added slowly to get the right softness.

Stage 4: Kneading the Clay

- Clay is kneaded with **hands and feet** for 20–30 minutes.
- This makes it smooth and removes air bubbles that can cause breakage.
- **Stage 5:**
- A dome-shaped top called **Nadula** is added — this represents a temple.

Stage 6: Adding Figures and Details

- Human and animal figures are sculpted directly onto the slab.
- Tools like **Bhaledi** (pointed stick) are used for cutting fine lines.
- Patterns are made with combs, toothpicks, or wires.

Stage 7: Drying the Plaque

- Plaques are dried **in shade** for 7–11 days.
- Direct sun can cause cracks; drying is done slowly to keep them strong.

Stage 8: Firing in the Kiln

- Open kilns are built outside using bricks.
- Fired at **900–1000°C** using wood and cow dung as fuel.
- This hardens the clay permanently.

Stage 9: Painting

- Traditionally painted with **Geru** (red oxide) mixed with water.
- Now also painted with bright synthetic colors for modern customers.

Stage 10: Finishing

- A layer of **lacquer** is applied to make the plaque shiny and water-resistant.

Designs & Symbolism

Main Types of Designs

1. **Religious Plaques** – Show Hindu gods and goddesses worshipped by tribal communities.
   - **Devnarayan:** Protector of cattle, always shown riding a horse with a spear.
   - **Dharmaraj:** Symbol of justice and village safety.
   - **Bhairavnath:** Fierce protector deity.
     - **Kala Bhairav:** Fierce form, offered liquor and meat.
     - **Gora Bhairav:** Gentle form, offered sweets.
   - **Nagaraja:** Serpent king deity, believed to protect from snake bites.
2. **Folk Story Plaques** – Show legends, village tales, or life events.
   - Rasleela dance of Krishna with Radha and Gopis.
   - Marriage processions, fairs, and harvest celebrations.
3. **Modern/Decorative Designs** – For home décor and gifts.
   - Village scenes, animals, floral borders, temple entrances.
   - Inspired by **Harappan seals** and Rajasthani miniature paintings.

Symbolism in Motifs

- **Nadula Dome:** Symbol of a temple; shows sanctity and divine protection.
- **Wheels (Chakra):** Represents the cycle of life and time.
- **Floral Borders:** Stands for nature, fertility, and beauty.
- **Temple Pillars:** Sign of strength, support, and tradition.

Colors & Their Meanings

- **Red (Geru):** Purity and energy.
- **Yellow:** Prosperity and happiness.
- **Blue:** Calmness and devotion (often linked to Krishna).
- **White:** Peace and simplicity.

Significance of the Craft

- **Cultural Value:** Molela plaques are storytelling in clay depicting deities, legends, and village life.
- **Religious Importance:** Many tribal communities believe these plaques protect homes and livestock.
- **Economic Impact:** Main source of income for 60% of Molela households.
- **Tourism Potential:** Attracts visitors, researchers, and documentary filmmakers.
- **Heritage Preservation:** Keeps alive an 800-year-old tradition that's rare in India.

PRODUCT RANGE

PRODUCT	Sizes	Price
Traditional Plaques	1 x 1 ft	800
	2.25 x 2.25 ft	1800-2000
	3 x 3 ft	
	4 x 4 ft	
Village theme tiles	4" x 4"	200-250
	9" x 9"	400-500
	1 x 1 ft	800-1000
Ganesh ji tiles	4" x 4"	200-250
	9" x 9"	400-500
	1 x 1 ft	800-1000
Radha Krishna tiles	4" x 4"	200-250
	9" x 9"	700-800
	1 x 1 ft	900-1000

Extra details:

- Urban and export prices are much higher than village sales.
- Artisans often get less profit if selling through middlemen.

Product Usage

Religious:

- Installed in **devras** (village shrines) and small temples.
- Annual replacement ritual during *Magh* month.
- Used in household altars for daily worship.

Decorative:

- Wall panels in hotels, resorts, and cultural centers.
- Mounted in gardens and courtyards for heritage feel.

Functional:

- Nameplates, wall hooks, lamp bases.
- Combined with wood or metal for furniture decoration.

Gifting:

- Given as wedding or festival gifts.
- Souvenirs for tourists visiting Rajasthan.

Packaging

Traditional Method:

- Plaques wrapped in **dry straw or old cloth** to prevent scratches.
- Bundled with jute rope for carrying on foot or by cart.
- Ideal for short-distance delivery to nearby villages.

Modern Method:

- **Corrugated cardboard boxes** lined with bubble wrap for shock protection.
- Small silica gel pouches sometimes added to prevent moisture damage.
- For high-value plaques, foam padding used inside boxes.

Export Packaging:

- Packed in **wooden crates** lined with thermocol sheets.
- Sealed with “FRAGILE” labels in both English & Hindi.
- Extra plastic wrapping to protect against humidity during shipping.

Challenges:

- Traditional packaging is cheap but not weather-proof.
- Modern packaging is costly and adds to product price.
- Lack of branded, eco-friendly packaging reduces urban appeal

ABOUT THE MAKERSSSSSS

PRODUCT QUALITY

- **Choosing the Clay:** Use only soft, fine clay from the Banas River, free from stones or dirt.
- **Mixing Carefully:** Keep the right balance of clay, donkey dung, and wheat husk so the plaques are strong and don’t crack.
- **Shaping Evenly:** Make sure the plaque is the same thickness all over to stop it from breaking in the kiln.
- **Checking Drying:** Let the plaques dry slowly in shade, then inspect them before firing.
- **Controlled Firing:** Heat them at the right temperature so they become hard and long-lasting.
- **Perfect Finish:** Apply paint and lacquer smoothly; smooth out any rough edges.
- **Final Check:** Look over each plaque to make sure there are no cracks, chips, or paint problems before packing and selling.

Customers

Local:

- Tribal communities (Bhil, Garasiya, Rawat) from Rajasthan, Gujarat, MP.
- Buy during *Magh* month for annual shrine renewal.

Urban/National:

- Hotels, resorts, interior designers.
- Art collectors and boutiques.

International:

- Exported as wall art, cultural décor.
- Used in heritage hotels and museums abroad.

Who Buys Them

Before	Now
Tribals for worship	**Tourists, collectors, hotels**
Sold only in village	**Sold in fairs, shops, and online**

Hotels and resorts use them for cultural interior décor.

Some temples outside Rajasthan now order custom panels.

Markets & Marketing Channels (Detailed)

Local Market:

- Sold directly to tribal buyers from Rajasthan, Gujarat, and Madhya Pradesh.
- Highest demand in *Magh* month fairs.

National Market:

- Government emporiums like Rajasthali.
- Handicraft fairs such as Surajkund Mela, Shilpgram Udaipur.

- Private boutiques in Jaipur, Delhi, and Mumbai.

International Market:

- Exported via NGOs, EPCH (Export Promotion Council for Handicrafts), and private dealers.
- Popular in heritage hotels, cultural museums, and art galleries abroad.

Marketing Channels:

- Direct sales at fairs.
- Through middlemen/traders.
- Online marketing via Instagram, Facebook, Etsy, and Amazon Handmade.
- Collaborations with architects & interior designers for custom installations.

USP (Unique Selling Points)

1. Only from Molela

- The plaques are made only in Molela village, nowhere else in the world.
- Protected by **GI Tag** (Geographical Indication) which proves authenticity.

2. Handmade, Eco-friendly

- Made from river clay, donkey dung, and wheat husk — all natural materials.
- No harmful chemicals used in traditional method.

3. Cultural & Religious Value

- Designs show gods, folk stories, and village life.
- Many buyers believe the plaques protect homes and cattle.

4. Lightweight & Portable

- Hollow design makes them easy to carry long distances, unlike heavy stone idols.

5. Every Piece is Unique

- Made entirely by hand, so no two plaques are exactly the same.

6. Blend of Art & Storytelling

- Plaques are not just decoration — they tell local legends and myths through clay.

Importance of GI Tag

- Legally protects craft from imitation.
- Creates a brand identity for Molela.
- Increases buyer trust.
- Helps in premium pricing in national and international markets.

SWOT Analysis

Strengths:

- Exclusive to Molela, protected by **GI tag**.
- Handmade using eco-friendly, locally sourced materials.
- Deep cultural and religious connection for tribal buyers.
- Lightweight and portable due to hollow design.

Weaknesses:

- Seasonal clay availability limits year-round production.
- Small-scale family workshops; no large production capacity.
- Poor health and safety measures for artisans.
- Limited awareness in global markets.

Opportunities:

- Rising interest in sustainable, handcrafted décor.
- Potential for product diversification (jewelry, accessories, nameplates).
- Tourism workshops in collaboration with Rajasthan heritage circuits.
- E-commerce sales via Etsy, Amazon Handmade, and Instagram shops.

Threats:

- Competition from cheaper, machine-made religious idols.
- Changing weather patterns affecting clay drying & firing.
- Younger generation leaving craft for other jobs.

Health Problems for Artisans

Body Strain:

- Back pain from bending for hours.
- Hand and wrist pain from kneading and shaping clay.

Breathing Issues:

- Clay dust during cleaning causes coughing, asthma risk.

Heat Problems:

- Firing in open kilns causes dehydration and heat stress.

Extra details:

- Most workshops have poor ventilation.
- Very few artisans wear masks or protective gloves.

Main Challenges

- Clay available only in some seasons.
- Cheap factory-made products reduce demand.
- Young generation is moving to other jobs.
- Weather changes make drying and firing difficult.
- No regular medical check-ups for health problems.

DATABASE ON ARTISANS

DATABASE ON NGOS

Name of Organization	Contact Person	Address	Years of Existence	Phone / Mobile	Nature of Work
SPIC MACAY	Sandeep Chandoke (State Coordinator), Anu Chandoke (Artist Coordinator)	A, Kriti Nagar, Tonk Road, Jaipur	~47 years (since 1977)	9314883133, 9829228889	Society for promotion of Indian classical music and culture amongst youth
Surabhi Foundation	Siddharth Kak (Founder)	Bungalow No. 179, RSC 2, Survey No. 120, S.V.P. Nagar, Mhada, Near Versova Telephone Exchange, Four Bungalows, Andheri (W), Mumbai – 400053	~10+ years	+91 (22) 6551 4723-25	Rural development, farmer/artisan empowerment, organic farming, traditional art & craft marketing
INTACH (Indian National Trust for Art and Cultural Heritage)	—	—	~40 years (since 1984)	—	Heritage preservation, craft documentation, design, education, exhibitions, conservation training

Rajsamand – Tourist Places

1. **Nathdwara** – Town famous for the **Shrinathji Temple** of Lord Krishna, beautiful **Picchhwai paintings**, silver jewelry, and sweets.
2. **Rajsamand Lake** – Big man-made lake with marble ghats (steps) and old stone carvings. Great for boating and evening walks.
3. **Kumbhalgarh Fort** – UNESCO site with the **second-longest wall in the world** (36 km), over 360 temples, and amazing hill views.
4. **Haldighati** – Historic battlefield of Maharana Pratap; also known for **yellow soil**, roses, and nearby terracotta villages.

Old Packaging	New Packaging
Wrapped in dry grass, hay, or cloth	Wrapped in bubble wrap and thermocol sheets
Tied with jute rope	Packed in cardboard boxes or wooden crates
Transported on donkeys, bullock carts, or on foot	Labeled “Fragile” for safe handling
Cheap and easily available materials	Suitable for long travel and export
Not safe in bad weather; high breakage risk	Protects from moisture and damage
—	More costly, sometimes not eco-friendly

Product	Size	Price (₹)
Traditional Plaques	1 × 1 ft	800
	2.25 × 2.25 ft	1800–2000
	3 × 3 ft	—
	4 × 4 ft	—
Village Theme Tiles	4" × 4"	200–250
	9" × 9"	400–500
	1 × 1 ft	800–1000
Ganesh Ji Tiles	4" × 4"	200–250
	9" × 9"	400–500
	1 × 1 ft	800–1000
Radha Krishna Tiles	4" × 4"	200–250
	9" × 9"	700–800
	1 × 1 ft	900–1000

1. Packaging Solutions

Old Method:

- Plaques were packed tightly in straw, cloth, and hay.

- The natural materials absorbed shocks when donkeys carried them over bumpy paths.
- Breakage was rare because the items didn't move inside the bundle.

New Design Idea:

- Create **eco-friendly modular boxes** made from coir, jute, or strawboard.
- Add **soft natural padding** inside (like compressed straw panels).
- Make **stackable bamboo crates** for bulk transport that can be reused.
- Design **foldable carry straps** or bags so artisans can carry plaques easily to fairs.

2. Comfortable Workstations

Old Method:

- Artisans sat on the floor with the clay at a comfortable height.
- Work was done in open courtyards, so they could change positions easily.

New Design Idea:

- Low stools with back support to reduce back pain.
- **Rotating clay platforms** (like a flat potter's wheel) so they don't have to bend or turn their bodies too much.
- Tool pouches or stands to keep tools close at hand and avoid unnecessary bending.

3. Health Protection

Old Method:

- Workspaces were open and airy, so dust didn't stay in the air for long.
- Hands were protected naturally with clay and water, so skin didn't dry as much.

New Design Idea:

- **Breathable cotton masks** with replaceable natural filters to protect from clay dust.
- Small, covered clay-mixing tables to stop dust from spreading.
- Washable, clay-friendly gloves to protect skin during long work hours.

4. Selling & Branding

Old Method:

- Crafts were sold in local fairs, where artisans told stories about the products.
- Buyers remembered the personal connection and came back every year.

New Design Idea:

- Portable **display stands** that fold and fit into small bags for fairs.
- **QR codes** on product tags that link to short videos about the artisan's story and process.
- Attractive, reusable fabric bags with Molela art prints to give buyers a premium feel.

5. Storage Before Sale

Old Method:

- Plaques were stored upright in straw-filled rooms, which kept them from scratching each other.
- The straw also absorbed moisture.

New Design Idea:

- **Lightweight storage racks** with soft padded dividers between plaques.
- Natural fiber linings (like jute or banana fiber) to keep the eco-friendly touch.
- Racks can be **foldable** so they take less space when not in use.